



Inclusion to Exclude: How Femonationalism Impacts Policy Preferences - Sophie Mainz (2026)

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Femonationalism



- RQ: How does femonationalism, defined as the selective invocation of gender equality to promote exclusionary anti-immigrant policies, affect citizens?
- Femonationalism (Farris, 2017) = the exploitation of feminist themes by nationalists and neoliberals in anti-Islam campaigns, the participation of feminists in the stigmatization of Muslim men under the pretext of gender equality
- Context: France, The Netherlands, Italy
- Femonationalism (Mainz, 2026) = selectively invoking gender equality to justify anti-immigrant policies by political actors
- Context: USA

Hypotheses



- **Cognitive Dissonance Theory** -> psychological disturbance that a person feels when realising that two or more of their beliefs, views, or values are conflicting
- **Social Identity Theory** - > individuals are motivated to retain a positive self-image and engage in activities that boost their own group's positive distinctiveness

- **H1 (Disidentification Thesis):** Exposure to femonationalist speech by a politician from a party that represents a **conservative immigration stance** makes individuals with **anti-immigration attitudes** more supportive of **gender equality policies**.
- **H2 (Liberal Compromise Thesis):** Exposure to femonationalist speech by a politician from a party that represents an **inclusionary immigration stance** makes individuals with **pro-immigration attitudes** more supportive of **stricter integration policies**.

Methodology

Treatment group	T1 n = 613	T2 n = 605	T3 n = 648	T4 n = 654	Control (C) n = 598
Sender	Republican	Republican	Democratic	Democratic	no vignette
Message	immigrants as a threat to gender equality (value threat)	immigrants as a threat to women's safety (safety threat)	immigrants as a threat to gender equality (value threat)	immigrants as a threat to women's safety (safety threat)	
Outcomes	Support for gender policies (0 “Strongly disagree” – 10 “Strongly agree”): “Teaching women's rights and gender equality should be a substantial part of the educational curriculum in American public schools.” “Schools should include mandatory lessons on sexual consent in their curricula.” Support for stricter integration policies (0 “Strongly disagree” – 10 “Strongly agree”): “English language ability should be a prerequisite for becoming U.S. citizen.” “There should be an immigration policy in place that requires new immigrants to take mandatory classes that focus on American societal norms and values and how to integrate into the U.S.”				

Methodology

Pre-amble: Below is an excerpt from an interview with a prominent [Republican/Democratic] senator. Please read the text carefully, we will ask you some questions about it later on.

Vignette T1: Republican politician x value threat condition

Interviewer: Does immigration threaten gender equality?

Republican Senator: Unfortunately, many immigrants do not respect our core American values such as gender equality and freedom from discrimination. We see a higher prevalence of traditional, restrictive views on women's roles among some immigrant communities. Oppressive attitudes toward women are not part of our free society. Women need to be able to freely choose their careers, appearance, and who they want to be with. We need to make sure that immigrants learn and understand this.

Vignette T2: Republican politician x safety threat condition

Interviewer: Does immigration threaten women's safety?

Republican Senator: Unfortunately, many immigrants do not respect the safety and liberties of women. We see a higher number of incidents of harassment and violence against women among some immigrant communities. Violent behavior toward women is not part of our free society. Women need to be able to move freely, without fear of crime and without threats of danger. We need to make sure that immigrants learn and understand this.

Vignette T3: Democratic politician x value threat condition

Interviewer: Does immigration threaten gender equality?

Democratic Senator: Unfortunately, many immigrants do not respect our core American values such as gender equality and freedom from discrimination. We see a higher prevalence of traditional, restrictive views on women's roles among some immigrant communities. Oppressive attitudes toward women are not part of our free society. Women need to be able to freely choose their careers, appearance, and who they want to be with. We need to make sure that immigrants learn and understand this.

Vignette T4: Democratic politician x safety threat condition

Interviewer: Does immigration threaten women's safety?

Democratic Senator: Unfortunately, many immigrants do not respect the safety and liberties of women. We see a higher number of incidents of harassment and violence against women among some immigrant communities. Violent behavior toward women is not part of our free society. Women need to be able to move freely, without fear of crime and without threats of danger. We need to make sure that immigrants learn and understand this.

Model and Variables

Variable name:		immigration		
Data type:		Numeric		
Unique non-missing value count:		194		
Missing value count:		0		
Description:		Respondent's pre-treatment attitude towards immigrants		
Min	Mean	Median	Max	SD
0.00	57.26	54.50	100.00	20.50

- Two OLS models with the same covariates, but different outcomes:

$$Y_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{Treatment}_i + \beta_2 \text{ImmigrationAttitudes}_i + \beta_3 \text{Treatment}_i \times \text{ImmigrationAttitudes}_i + \epsilon_i$$

Variable name:		integration		
Data type:		Numeric		
Unique non-missing value count:		21		
Missing value count:		0		
Description:		Support for stricter integration demands, outcome variable, post-treatment		
Min	Mean	Median	Max	SD
0.00	6.16	6.50	10.00	2.93

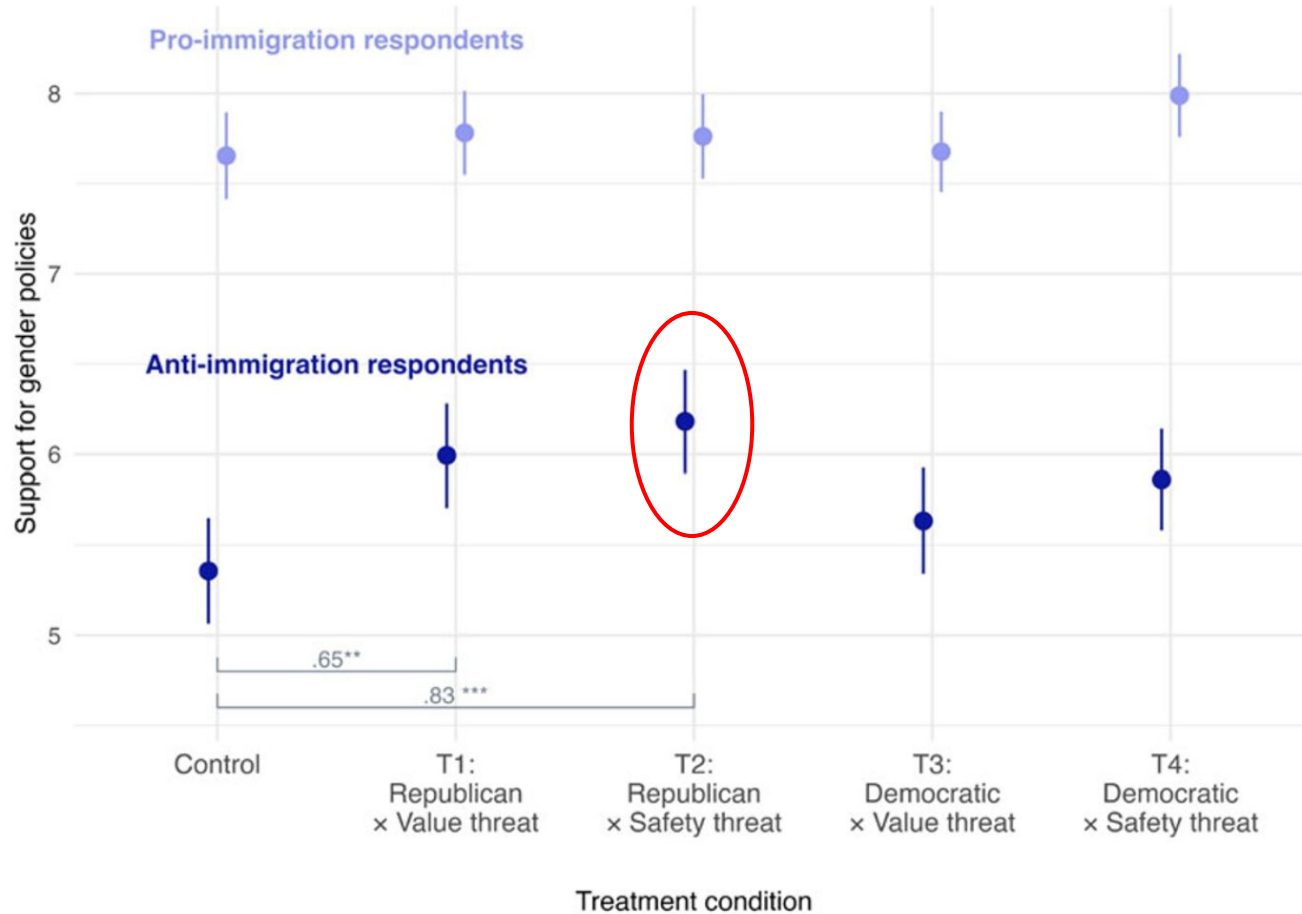
Variable name:		genderpolicies		
Data type:		Numeric		
Unique non-missing value count:		21		
Missing value count:		0		
Description:		Support for gender education policies, outcome variable, post-treatment		
Min	Mean	Median	Max	SD
0.00	7.04	7.50	10.00	2.75

Models

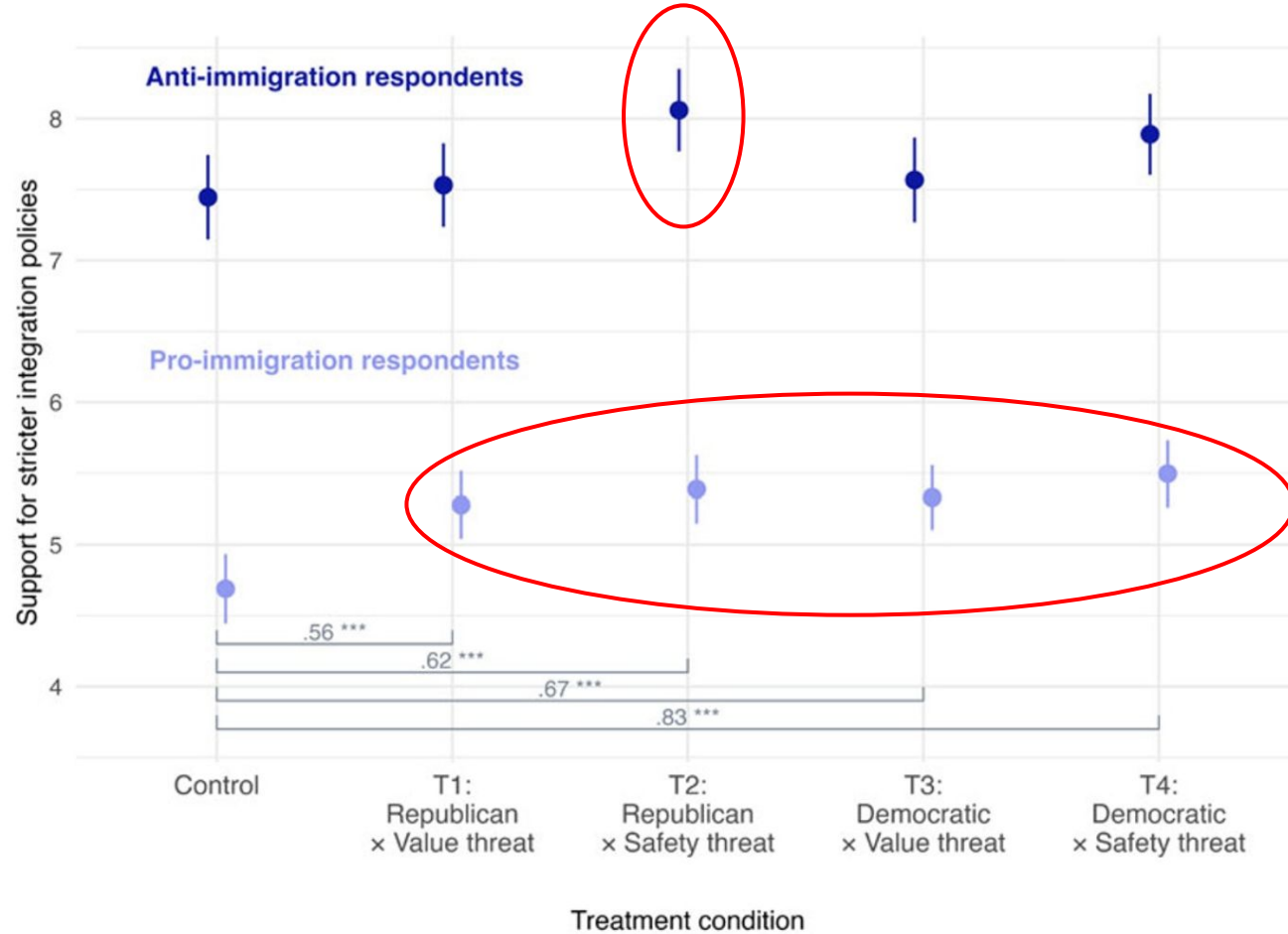
	<i>Dependent variable:</i> support for gender policies
treatmentt1	0.905** (0.420)
treatmentt2	1.211*** (0.424)
treatmentt3	0.506 (0.411)
treatmentt4	0.490 (0.413)
immigration	0.062*** (0.005)
treatmentt1:immigration	-0.010 (0.007)
treatmentt2:immigration	-0.015** (0.007)
treatmentt3:immigration	-0.006 (0.007)
treatmentt4:immigration	-0.002 (0.007)
Constant	3.230*** (0.292)

	<i>Dependent variable:</i> support for stricter integration policies
treatmentt1	-0.126 (0.428)
treatmentt2	1.007** (0.432)
treatmentt3	-0.352 (0.419)
treatmentt4	0.303 (0.421)
immigration	-0.075*** (0.005)
treatmentt1:immigration	0.009 (0.007)
treatmentt2:immigration	-0.005 (0.007)
treatmentt3:immigration	0.013* (0.007)
treatmentt4:immigration	0.007 (0.007)
Constant	9.998*** (0.298)

Findings



Findings



Twist

Policy Preference $\sim$ Treatment $\times$ Party + Immigration

Model 1: `genderpolicies ~ treatment * immigration`

Model 2: `genderpolicies ~ treatment * party_collapsed + immigration`

Res.Df	RSS	Df	Sum of Sq	F	Pr(>F)
1	3100	19251			
2	3094	16985	6	2265.4	68.777

< 2.2e-16 ***

Signif. codes: 0 '***' 0.001 '**' 0.01 '*' 0.05 '.' 0.1 ' ' 1

Model 1: `integration ~ treatment * immigration`

Model 2: `integration ~ treatment * party_collapsed + immigration`

Res.Df	RSS	Df	Sum of Sq	F	Pr(>F)
1	3100	20029			
2	3094	18317	6	1712.5	48.213

< 2.2e-16 ***

Signif. codes: 0 '***' 0.001 '**' 0.01 '*' 0.05 '.' 0.1 ' ' 1

DV: gender policies

treatmentt1	0.025 (0.205)
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treatmentt2	-0.203 (0.208)
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treatmentt3	-0.012 (0.202)
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treatmentt4	0.130 (0.201)
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party_collapsedIndependent	-1.112*** (0.341)
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party_collapsedRepublican	-2.652*** (0.208)
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immigration	0.033*** (0.002)
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treatmentt1:party_collapsedRepublican	0.705** (0.285)
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treatmentt2:party_collapsedRepublican	1.179*** (0.286)
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treatmentt3:party_collapsedRepublican	0.568** (0.281)
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treatmentt4:party_collapsedRepublican	0.730*** (0.279)
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DV: integration policies

treatmentt1	0.688*** (0.213)
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treatmentt2	0.853*** (0.216)
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treatmentt3	0.843*** (0.210)
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treatmentt4	1.111*** (0.209)
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party_collapsedIndependent	0.879** (0.354)
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party_collapsedRepublican	2.308*** (0.216)
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immigration	-0.050*** (0.002)
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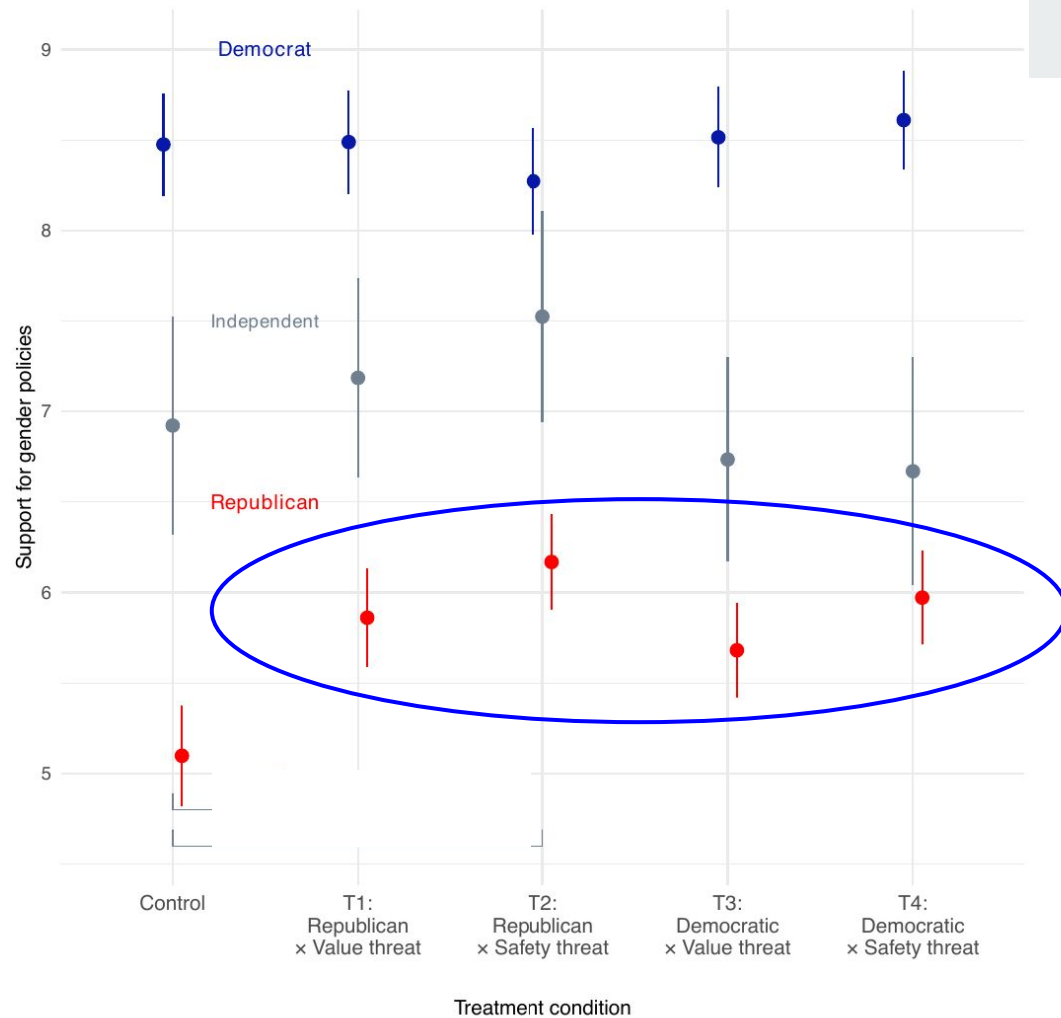
treatmentt1:party_collapsedRepublican	-0.623** (0.296)
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treatmentt2:party_collapsedRepublican	-0.343 (0.297)
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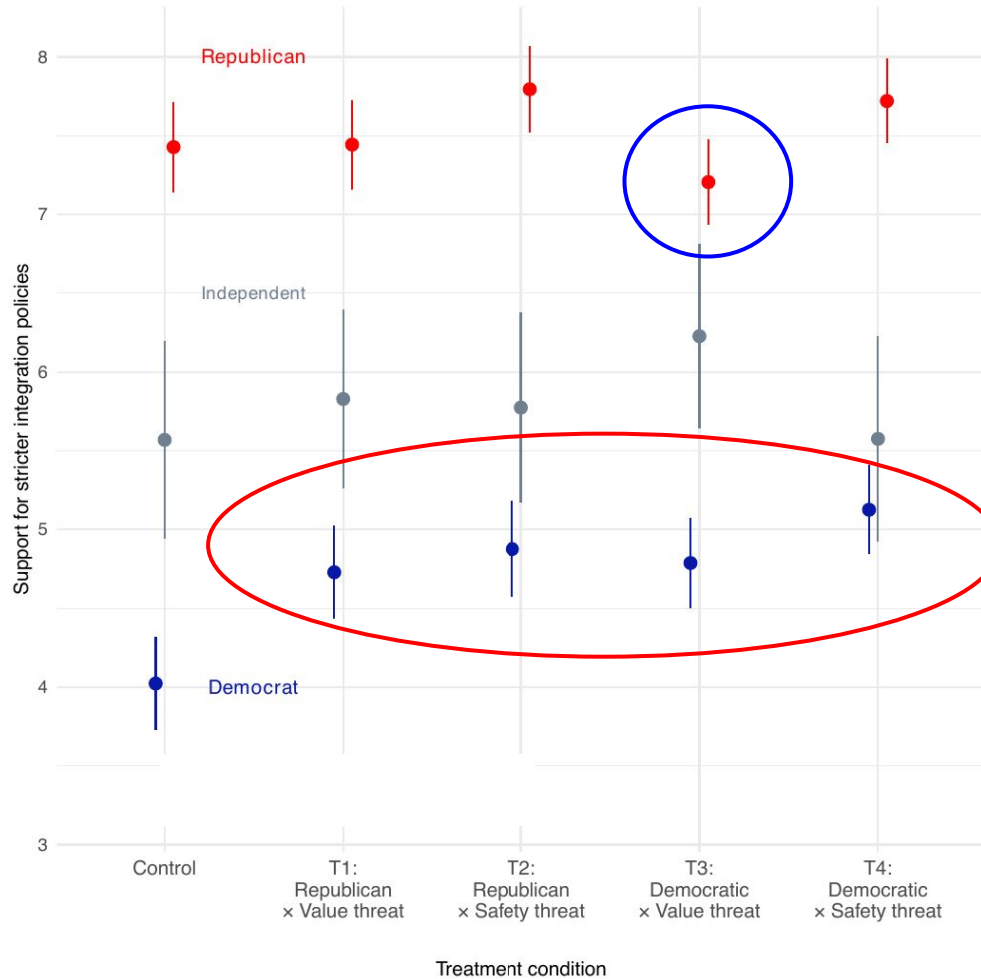
treatmentt3:party_collapsedRepublican	-1.023*** (0.291)
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treatmentt4:party_collapsedRepublican	-0.797*** (0.289)
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Twist



Twist



Findings



- Republicans become more supportive of gender equality policies after exposure to femonationalist speech regardless of message source
- Democrats become more supportive of stricter integration policies, also independent of message source
- Responses seem to be driven more by partisan identity than message source - people in the same partisan group react similarly
- Partisanship might be a stronger moderator of policy views than immigration stance
- Femonationalist rhetoric can generate unexpected attitude shifts - more liberal Republicans and less liberal Democrats
- Femonationalism behaves differently in heavily polarized contexts (?)



References

Farris, S. R. (2017). In the name of womens rights: The rise of femonationalism. Duke University Press. <https://doi.org/10.1215/9780822372929>

Mainz, S. (2026). *Inclusion to exclude: How femonationalism impacts policy preferences*. *Political Science Research and Methods*. Advance online publication. <https://doi.org/10.1017/psrm.2025.10068>